then prime minister of India, Indira Gandhi, was assassinated by her Sikh bodyguards. This was followed by anti-Sikh riots in Delhi and targeted attacks by Khalistani extremists. The biggest attack was mounted in June 1985 when an Air India flight from Toronto to London was bombed, killing 329 passengers.

Desperate times need desperate measures and the R&AW launched a manhunt to track down suspected radicals holed up in the UK, the USA, Canada and other places. Many of these extremist leaders were getting active support from the ISI and the R&AW operatives were directed to choke the supply lines and counter the growth of armed terrorist groups. Despite R&AW efforts, several targeted killings were executed by Sikh extremists in 1986-87 including the killing of Hindus in Hoshiarpur and Mohali. Another objective of the R&AW was to counter the influence of the radical leaders on the younger generations of Sikhs abroad. The Indian intelligence agency analysed the strengths and weaknesses of key figures backing the Khalistan movement before coming up with an operational plan with superb tactics and matchless tradecraft. Today, with real-time digital intelligence, the R&AW has been warned of Sikh extremists abroad who are trying to resume the Khalistan movement by launching a referendum in 2020.

Americans Knew

The R&AW tried to understand why America allowed Khalistani forces to use its soil against India. Mathur said he had once told a Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) officer about Khalistan militants in the US national capital, but was bluntly informed that they were no threat to America. When Mathur provided files on several high profile militants that had been provided by Suchcha Singh, the Americans reluctantly arrested some of